

By **Pushpesh Pant**

Teacher, anchor and author of India: The Cookbook, The Indian Vegetarian Cookbook *and* Gourmet Journeys in India. *Views are personal*



Illustration by NILANJAN DAS

Spreading Bitterness

A vicious identity politics mixes food with hate speech and majoritarian prejudices to erase the memory of our pluralistic traditions

It started with the lynching of persons suspected of cattle-lifting, presumably for cow slaughter and those transporting or storing prohibited meat at home. Vigilantes had no time or patience for the law to take its own course. They took upon themselves the roles of police, jury, judge and executioner. Unfortunately, these horrendous incidents were treated as random aberrations. The miscreants went unpunished, encouraging others to indulge in this bloody sport under the garb of saving religion and nation. '*Gau rakshak*' suddenly emerged from the closet and replaced